

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

MURDER AT THE **Blue Lantern Club**

A 1920s Masquerade Murder Mystery Party

8-16 PLAYERS

2-2.5 HOURS

PRINTABLE PDF



FILE 01

Host Guide

Prep checklist · casting · run sheets · Scripts 1-4 · menu · printing

This cover page is optional: skip page 1 when you print to save paper.

INK-SAVER COVER · PRINTS CLEANLY IN BLACK AND WHITE

You can host this



No experience needed. Read this guide once, follow it from top to bottom, and you are ready. You never need to know the answer in advance: it is sealed in file 99.

The story

Gull Harbor, 1926. At the Blue Lantern Club, owner **Augustus “Gus” Whitlock** is hosting the Midnight Moon Masquerade and has promised an announcement at midnight “that will change everything”. At 11:58 pm the lights go out for ninety seconds. When they come back, Gus is slumped in a velvet armchair by the champagne tower, no longer breathing: something was slipped into his drink. **Inspector Sloane Whitaker**, who happened to be a guest (that’s you), must find out who did it before the night is over.

How the game works

1. **Before the party:** give every guest a character and send the invitations with costume ideas.
2. **Arrival (15 min):** guests read the cover and “Before the game” in their booklets.
3. **Opening (5 min):** you read Script 1.
4. **Three rounds (25–30 min each):** you reveal six evidence cards per round. Each booklet tells its player what to share, who to question and what to hide. In Round 1, everyone swaps the rumour on their Rumor card.
5. **Accusations (10 min):** everyone fills in a ballot.
6. **The unmasking (10 min):** you open the sealed solution, read Script 5 and hand out awards.

YOUR ROLE: INSPECTOR SLOANE WHITAKER

You run the rounds, read the scripts and question the suspects, so you are part of the party all night. Read the sealed solution early if you like to steer, or keep it sealed and solve it with your guests.

TIME

About 2 to 2.5 hours with a food break. A New Year’s Eve schedule that puts the unmasking at about 11:30 pm is on page 7.

Prep checklist



Two weeks before

- ☐ Count your guests and choose the cast with the table on page 4.
- ☐ Give each guest a character.
- ☐ Send invitations: printed (02-Invitations.pdf), typed (Invitation-Maker.html) or by phone (E-Invites folder).

One week before

- ☐ Print the files you need (page 14). Black and white is fine.
- ☐ Cut out the evidence cards (30), Rumor cards (36), name tags (31) and ballots (32).
- ☐ Fold each booklet and write the character's name on the outside, or use envelopes. Players must never see each other's booklets.
- ☐ Plan the food and drinks (ideas on page 13).

The day before

- ☐ Read this guide and Scripts 1–4 aloud once.
- ☐ Print 99-SOLUTION-Host-Only.pdf last, put it in an envelope and seal it.
- ☐ Optional: print and cut the masks, banner and photo signs (35-Party-Decor.pdf).

On the night

- ☐ Set up an evidence table with the “Evidence Table” sign.
- ☐ Stack the evidence cards face down in three piles: Round 1, 2 and 3.
- ☐ Hand each arriving guest a booklet, a name tag, a Rumor card and a Detective Notes sheet.
- ☐ Keep pens and ballots ready for the end.

Choosing the cast

The eight **core** characters are always played. Add optional characters in the order below. Everything needed to solve the case is on the evidence cards and in the core booklets, so the mystery stays solvable whichever optional characters you use.

PLAYERS	CAST
8	Core only: Remy Quill, Avery Lark, Jordan Pierce, Sidney Hart, Morgan Bellamy, Frankie Dade, Charlie Ashby, Dana Rook
9	+ Leslie Croft (Gus's lawyer)
10	+ Billie Sable (coat-check attendant)
11	+ Robin Vale (aviator)
12	+ Jesse Monroe (photographer)
13	+ Kit Haverford (shipping heir)
14	+ Taylor Moss (stage magician)
15	+ Emery Fontaine (dance instructor)
16	+ Marion Kettle (club chef): every booklet in play
17-20	All 16 characters + Gossip Guest A, B, C, D in that order (file 37). Gossip Guests have no secret; they collect rumours and vote.

CASTING

The host plays Inspector Sloane Whitaker. Give every other role to a guest. Every role works for anyone: the names are gender-neutral and each character has a suit style and a dress style.

GOSSIP GUESTS (17-20 PLAYERS)

Extra guests get a Gossip Guest card (file 37), a name tag and a ballot. They have no secret: they mingle, trade the rumours on their card, question suspects and vote.

Removable characters

Drop optional characters from the bottom of the list first. None of them carries a clue the case depends on: they add colour, extra witnesses and helpful hints.

CHARACTER	TYPE	ORDER	IF LEFT OUT
Remy Quill	Core	Always	Keep this role
Avery Lark	Core	Always	Keep this role
Jordan Pierce	Core	Always	Keep this role
Sidney Hart	Core	Always	Keep this role
Morgan Bellamy	Core	Always	Keep this role
Frankie Dade	Core	Always	Keep this role
Charlie Ashby	Core	Always	Keep this role
Dana Rook	Core	Always	Keep this role
Leslie Croft	Optional	Adds at 9 players	Safe to remove
Billie Sable	Optional	Adds at 10 players	Safe to remove
Robin Vale	Optional	Adds at 11 players	Safe to remove
Jesse Monroe	Optional	Adds at 12 players	Safe to remove
Kit Haverford	Optional	Adds at 13 players	Safe to remove
Taylor Moss	Optional	Adds at 14 players	Safe to remove
Emery Fontaine	Optional	Adds at 15 players	Safe to remove
Marion Kettle	Optional	Adds at 16 players	Safe to remove

If someone cannot come

- ♦ **An optional player cancels:** leave that booklet out and skip that character's Rumor card. Nothing else changes.
- ♦ **A core player cancels:** move an optional player into the core role and drop the optional role.
- ♦ **Short of a core player on the night:** read that character's Round lines aloud at the start of each round as "a statement given to the Inspector".
- ♦ **Extra guests turn up:** hand out Gossip Guest cards, or let two guests share one role as a pair.

Run sheet: the standard party

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	YOU DO
0:00	Guests arrive, drinks, costumes, photos	Hand out booklets, name tags, Rumor cards and notes. Players read their cover and “Before the game” only
0:15	Opening + Round 1	Read Script 1 . Reveal Evidence 1–6 . Players read Round 1 and swap rumours
0:45	Food break	Players stay in character if they like
1:05	Round 2	Read Script 2 . Reveal Evidence 7–12
1:35	Round 3	Read Script 3 . Reveal Evidence 13–18
2:00	Accusations	Read Script 4 . Ballots out, 10 minutes
2:10	The unmasking	Open the sealed file, read Script 5 , give out awards. Done by about 2:25

What players read, and when

WHEN	PLAYERS READ	EVIDENCE ON THE TABLE
On arrival	Booklet cover and “Before the game”	None yet
Script 1	Round 1 and their Rumor card	#1–6
Script 2	Round 2	#1–12
Script 3	Round 3 and their notes page	#1–18
Script 4	A ballot	All 18 cards

REVEALING EVIDENCE

Read each card aloud, then lay it face up on the evidence table so anyone can study it. Leave every card out until the end.

New Year's Eve run sheet

The unmasking is built for New Year's Eve: masks come off at the reveal, about 11:30 pm, leaving time for awards before the countdown.

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	YOU DO
8:45 pm	Guests arrive	Booklets, name tags, Rumor cards, drinks and photos
9:00 pm	Opening + Round 1	Script 1 , Evidence 1–6
9:35 pm	Supper	Food break, stay in character
10:05 pm	Round 2	Script 2 , Evidence 7–12
10:40 pm	Round 3	Script 3 , Evidence 13–18
11:10 pm	Accusations	Script 4 , ballots
11:25 pm	The unmasking	Script 5 from the sealed file: everyone takes off their mask
11:40 pm	Awards and photos	Certificates, then fill the coupes for midnight
12:00 am	Happy New Year!	Countdown, with the Blue Lantern banner overhead

NYE TIPS

- ♦ Running late? Shorten Rounds 2 and 3 to 20 minutes each; the reveal still lands before midnight.
- ♦ Serve sparkling juice or sparkling cider in coupes for the countdown, so everyone can toast.
- ♦ Hang the “THE BLUE LANTERN” banner and set out the photo signs for midnight pictures.

Script 1: The lights go out

“Good evening, everyone. My name is Inspector Sloane Whitaker, of the Gull Harbor police. I came to the Blue Lantern tonight in a borrowed mask, for the music and the champagne. I did not come to work.

At two minutes to midnight the lights went out. When they came back ninety seconds later, our host, Augustus Whitlock, everyone’s Gus, was slumped in the velvet chair beside the champagne tower. I am very sorry to tell you that Gus has died. A doctor among the guests believes something was put in his drink.

Gus promised us an announcement at midnight that would change everything. Somebody in this room made sure he never made it. Nobody leaves the Blue Lantern tonight.

Keep your masks on for now. Talk to each other, ask questions and trade the rumours you have heard. You may keep your own secrets for now, but you may not lie about the evidence. Here is what we know so far.”

Reveal Evidence 1–6. Players read Round 1 and start swapping Rumor cards.

EVIDENCE FOR ROUND 1

- ◆ #1 The Fuse Box
- ◆ #2 The Physician’s Note
- ◆ #3 The Gold-Rimmed Coupe
- ◆ #4 The Masquerade Program
- ◆ #5 The Coat-Check Ledger
- ◆ #6 The Gazette Column

ROUND CHECKLIST

- ☐ Read the script aloud.
- ☐ Read each card aloud, then lay it face up on the evidence table.
- ☐ Tell players to read Round 1 in their booklets.
- ☐ Give a two-minute warning before the next round.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AS THE INSPECTOR

- ◆ Dana, who carried Gus’s glass from the tower?
- ◆ Charlie, the whole town knows you are the silver fox. Where were you at 11:55?
- ◆ Avery, what could you see from the bandstand?
- ◆ Who has been in the service corridor tonight?

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

- ◆ Who knew Gus planned a midnight announcement?
- ◆ Who had a reason to be angry with Gus?
- ◆ Which masks were near the tower at 11:55?

Script 2: Paper trails

“Thank you for your patience, and for the supper. While you ate, I went through this club from the lobby to the greenhouse, and the Blue Lantern keeps better records than most police stations.

The telephone exchange has told me who was on the line at midnight. The greenhouse keeps a visitors’ book, and the gardener left a note on the door. A telegram arrived for Gus this morning that he never got to answer. And the balcony waiter writes down everything.

Some of you have been keeping secrets, and these papers suggest a few of them are about to come out. Read Round 2 in your booklets. Remember: secrets are allowed, lies about the evidence are not.”

Reveal Evidence 7–12. Players read Round 2.

EVIDENCE FOR ROUND 2

- ◆ #7 The Telephone Slip
- ◆ #8 The Greenhouse Visitors’ Book
- ◆ #9 The Gardener’s Note
- ◆ #10 The Expert’s Telegram
- ◆ #11 The Stage Cue Sheet
- ◆ #12 The Balcony Waiter’s Slip

ROUND CHECKLIST

- ☐ Read the script aloud.
- ☐ Read each card aloud, then lay it face up on the evidence table.
- ☐ Tell players to read Round 2 in their booklets.
- ☐ Give a two-minute warning before the next round.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AS THE INSPECTOR

- ◆ Charlie, the exchange has a slip with your name on it. Explain.
- ◆ To each name in the greenhouse book: why did you go in, and what did you see?
- ◆ Jordan and Morgan, what were you discussing on the balcony?
- ◆ Who sold Gus the seascapes in his gallery?

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

- ◆ Frankie, what did you hear when the lights went out?
- ◆ Sidney, what did you notice in the greenhouse?
- ◆ Whose story has changed since Round 1?

Script 3: The last round

“Midnight has come and gone, and the band has finally stopped playing. I have searched every corner of this club, and in a potted palm by the service corridor door I found something that should not have been there at all.

A theatrical shop on Harbor Street keeps a very tidy order book. The cloakroom has been holding a portfolio case with something rolled up inside. Gus’s own pocket has given up his midnight announcement, the photographer’s film has been developed, and a will has come to light.

This is the last round, so choose your questions carefully. When I call time, every one of you will put a name on a ballot.”

Reveal Evidence 13–18. Players read Round 3.

EVIDENCE FOR ROUND 3

- ◆ #13 The Mask in the Palm
- ◆ #14 The Delacroix Order Book
- ◆ #15 The Portfolio Case
- ◆ #16 Gus’s Midnight Card
- ◆ #17 The 11:55 Photograph
- ◆ #18 The New Will

ROUND CHECKLIST

- ☐ Read the script aloud.
- ☐ Read each card aloud, then lay it face up on the evidence table.
- ☐ Tell players to read Round 3 in their booklets.
- ☐ Give a two-minute warning before the next round.

QUESTIONS TO ASK AS THE INSPECTOR

- ◆ Whose name is in the Delacroix order book?
- ◆ Whose portfolio case was left under ticket No. 3?
- ◆ Who is wearing a peacock-feather pin tonight?
- ◆ Sidney, did you know about the new will?

IF THE ROOM GOES QUIET

- ◆ Who went into the greenhouse between 8:30 and 10:15?
- ◆ Which piece of evidence have we not talked about yet?
- ◆ Whose story has changed the most tonight?

Script 4: Accusations

“Time is up. The champagne is flat, the candles are low, and I have heard more secrets tonight than in a whole year of police work. Many of you had a reason to be cross with Gus Whitlock. Only one of you made sure he never reached midnight.

Take a ballot. Write down who did it, how and why, and the one clue that convinced you. Everyone fills one in, so nobody can tell who is who by watching.

You have ten minutes, and you may visit the evidence table one last time. Fold your ballot and hand it to me. Then I will open the sealed envelope, and we will all take off our masks.”

Collect the ballots. Script 5, the unmasking, is in the sealed 99-SOLUTION-Host-Only.pdf.

BALLOT CHECKLIST

- ☐ One ballot and a pen for every player.
- ☐ Gossip Guests vote too.
- ☐ Collect the folded ballots in a bowl or a hat.
- ☐ Open the sealed solution only now.

SCORING AT A GLANCE

3 points for the right **who**, 1 for **how**, 1 for **why**. Highest score wins Best Detective; on a tie, the best key clue wins. The answer key is in the sealed file.

OPTIONAL CLOSING STATEMENTS

Before ballots, give each core character 30 seconds to say “I am innocent because...”. It is great fun, and a last chance to spot a slip.

Hosting tips

- ◆ **Quiet guest?** Ask a direct question from that character's round: "Frankie, you were on the bandstand. What did you see?"
- ◆ **Nobody knows what to do?** Point them to their booklet: every round says what to share, what to hide and who to question.
- ◆ **Rumor cards** are the icebreaker. In Round 1, ask everyone to share their rumour with at least three people.
- ◆ **Moving too fast?** Spend longer on food, or use the "if the room goes quiet" questions under each script.
- ◆ **Moving too slowly?** Give a two-minute warning, then start the next round.
- ◆ **Keep the evidence visible.** Revealed cards stay face up on the evidence table all night.
- ◆ **Detective Notes** (file 33) help players keep track of motives, alibis and the 11:58 blackout.
- ◆ **Keep the answer safe.** Never leave the sealed solution or spare booklets where guests can find them.

CONTENT

Cozy, not gory: there is no blood, no weapons and no romance subplot, and drinks appear only as 1920s background. Suitable for ages 12+ and for work parties.

Decor, music & menu

Decor and props

- ◆ Hang the “THE BLUE LANTERN” banner and put out the photo signs and drink menu (35-Party-Decor.pdf).
- ◆ Gold, black and midnight blue: fairy lights, candles (LED is safest) and a paper moon.
- ◆ Stand the table signs (34) at the door, the evidence table and the drinks table.
- ◆ Props: a gold-rimmed glass, a pile of masks, a notebook and a magnifying glass.

Music

Play a 1920s jazz instrumental, ragtime, swing or big-band playlist from your favourite music service. Keep it quiet during rounds and louder during the food break.

Menu ideas

WHEN	SERVE
Arrival	Blue Lantern Fizz: sparkling lemonade with blueberries (alcohol-free)
Round 1	Harbor crab cakes or vegetable fritters
Food break	Gull Harbor chowder cups with crusty bread
Round 3	Midnight Moon cookies: crescent-shaped butter cookies
The unmasking	The champagne tower: coupes of sparkling grape juice or cider, with bubbly for adults if you like
All night	The Blue Lantern Bar menu card in file 35: three alcohol-free drinks listed first

Costumes

Every invitation and booklet gives a suit style and a dress style, plus a mask. Thrift-shop sequins, a bow tie, pearls or a fedora are plenty.

Printing & folding

FILE	COPIES
00 Start Here, 01 Host Guide	1 each, for you (or read on screen)
02 Invitations	1 per guest, or use the E-Invites / Invitation Maker
03 Cast List	1–2, for anyone to read
10–25 Booklets	1 per player: only the roles you use
26 All Booklets Combined	Optional: all 16 booklets in one file
30 Evidence Cards	1 set (pages 4–5 optional)
31 Name Tags · 32 Ballots	1 set · 1 ballot per player
33 Detective Notes	1 per player
34 Awards & Table Signs · 35 Party Decor	Optional
36 Rumor Cards	1 set · 37 Gossip Guests only for 17–20 players
99 Solution, host only	1, printed last, then sealed

- ◆ Use the folder that matches your paper: US-Letter or A4. Print at **Actual size / 100%**.
- ◆ Everything reads clearly in black and white. Covers: the ink-saver cover (page 1) is the default; the colour cover on the last page of files 00 and 01 is optional.
- ◆ Print masks, table signs and certificates on card stock if you can.
- ◆ **Folded booklet:** each booklet is 4 pages. Choose your printer's **Booklet** setting, print double-sided (flip on short edge) and fold the sheet in half. Or print the 4 pages single-sided and staple the corner.
- ◆ In the combined file every booklet starts on page 1, 5, 9 and so on, so double-sided printing never puts two characters on one sheet.

OPTIONAL COLOUR COVER · SKIP IT TO SAVE INK

MURDER AT THE Blue Lantern Club

A 1920s Masquerade Murder Mystery Party

HOST GUIDE



8-16 PLAYERS

2-2.5 HOURS

PRINTABLE PDF

16 separate character booklets · the host plays too
18 evidence cards · 4 printable masks · Letter + A4

AGES 12+ · WORK-FRIENDLY



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES